

A Manual of Trataka

An entry into Trataka, the yogic discipline of steady gazing, centred on our own core practice of Jyoti Trataka, candle gazing. Here you will find the full two-stage method, the second attention held at the chakras along the spine, the descent into the akashic trance, and a wider view of drishti and yantra across the tradition.

When the eyes are still, the mind is still. When the mind is still, the breath slows. When the breath slows, we enter the akasha. When the akasha is rested in, samadhi awakens.

PART ONE

Foundations of Trataka

What Trataka is, its place among the classical shatkarmas, and why candle gazing is our central form.

PART THREE

The Second Attention

Holding the chakras along the spine as a second thread of awareness during gazing practice.

PART FIVE

Drishti and the Wider Field

Gaze points across the yogic and tantric traditions, and a first word on yantra.

PART TWO

Jyoti Trataka: The Candle Practice

The full two-stage method: external gazing on the wick, then the held afterimage at ajna.

PART FOUR

The Akashic Trance

How stillness of the eyes leads to stillness of mind, breath, and the opening into akasha and samadhi.

The Discipline of the Steady Gaze

Trataka means steady gazing. It is counted among the shatkarmas, the six purificatory practices of hatha yoga, alongside Neti, Dhauti, Basti, Nauli, and Kapalabhati. Where those six work on the body, Trataka works directly on the eyes and, through the eyes, on the mind.

The classical texts describe many forms. One can gaze at a point on a wall, at the rising sun or moon, at the tip of the nose, at a yantra, at the image of a deity, or at a candle flame. All share the same root instruction: fix the sight on a single object and hold it there, without strain, until the mind itself grows still.

OUR CENTRAL PRACTICE

Within our school, the form we return to again and again is Jyoti Trataka, candle gazing, with attention held at the tip of the wick rather than the body of the flame. It is simple to set up, safe to practise alone, and rich enough to occupy a lifetime of refinement. Everything in this document builds from that one candle.



The steady flame. In Jyoti Trataka the gaze rests on the tip of the wick, not the flame's outer light.

Trataka is often introduced as a beginner's practice, a way to build concentration before moving to subtler work. That is true, but incomplete. In our school it is not a stepping stone to be discarded once mastered. It remains a full practice in its own right, one that continues to deepen the longer it is kept.

Why the Eyes Come First

The eyes are the most restless organs of the body. Even in seated meditation, with the body still and the breath slow, the eyes continue their small movements beneath closed lids, and the mind moves with them. Steady the eyes, and the mind has far less to hold onto.

This is the principle at the heart of every gazing practice, and it is worth stating plainly, because it is the thread that runs through this entire document.

When the eyes are still, the mind is still. When the mind is still, the breath slows. When the breath slows, we enter the akasha. When the akasha is rested in, samadhi awakens.

This is not a metaphor. It is a description of a sequence you can verify directly, on your own cushion, with your own candle. Each part of this document returns to some part of that sequence: the practice itself, the second attention at the chakras, and the trance state it opens onto.

None of this requires belief. It requires a candle, a dark room, and the willingness to sit with an open, unhurried patience. The instructions that follow are complete in themselves. Read them once, then let the practice teach you the rest.

PART TWO. JYOTITRATAKA: THE CANDLE PRACTICE



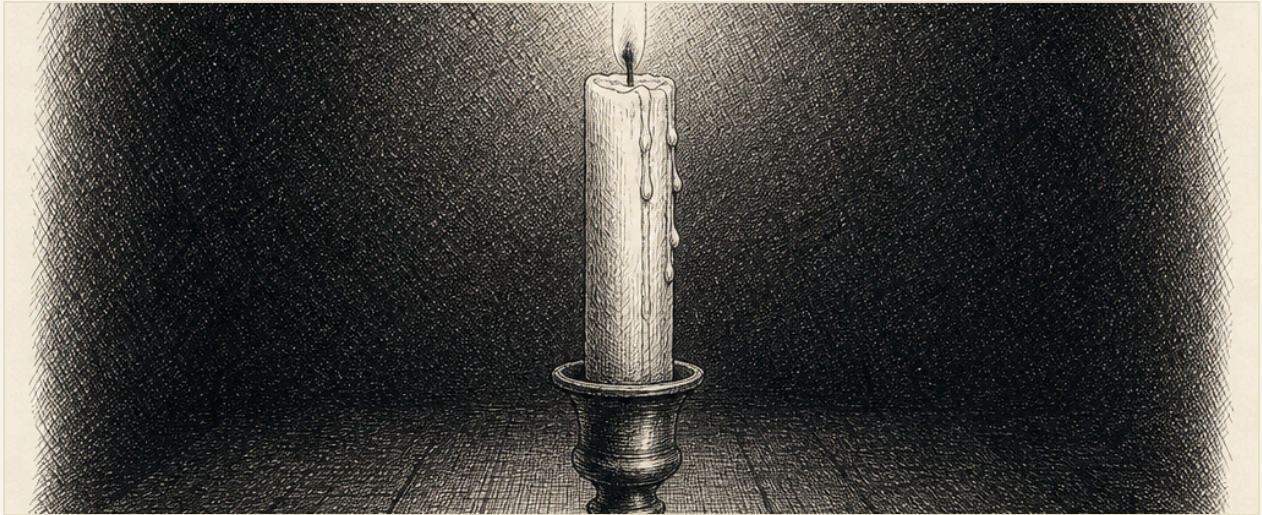
Preparing the Practice

Set a candle at eye level, roughly an arm's length away, in a room dark enough that the flame is the brightest thing in your field of vision. A steady flame matters more than a large one. If the candle is disturbed by draughts, move it or shield it before you begin.

Sit in whatever posture allows the spine to stay upright without effort. This is not a practice of forcing the body still while the eyes wander. The whole point is stillness gathered in one place, the gaze, and allowed to spread from there.

Before you begin

- **Distance and height:** The wick should sit level with your eyes or very slightly below, so the neck does not strain upward.
- **Darkness:** The room should be dark enough that the flame draws the eye without effort.
- **Time:** Ten to twenty minutes is a full session for most practitioners. Consistency across weeks matters more than length on any single day.
- **Attitude:** Relaxed, unhurried, without any goal beyond the gazing itself. Trataka is not a test.



A single flame in a darkened room is the whole of the outer setup this practice requires.

PART TWO. JYOTITRATAKA: THE CANDLE PRACTICE

IV

Stage One: The Open Gaze

Begin with the eyes open. Rest your gaze on the tip of the wick, the small point where flame meets wax, rather than the body of the flame itself. This is a deliberate choice. The tip of the wick is a fixed point; the flame around it moves and flickers, and if the gaze follows the flame's motion, the mind will follow it too.

Keep the gaze relaxed rather than fixed with effort. Let the eyelids soften. Do not fight the urge to blink either; simply hold the gaze as steadily and for as long as is comfortable, letting the periphery of your vision fall away.

① **Fix the gaze**

Rest attention on the tip of the wick, not the flame's outer light.

② **Soften, don't strain**

The eyes stay open and relaxed. Effort belongs to attention, not to the muscles of the face.

③ **Let the mind narrow**

As the gaze steadies, notice the mind gathering around the single point, other thoughts growing quieter of their own accord.

④ **Hold without forcing**

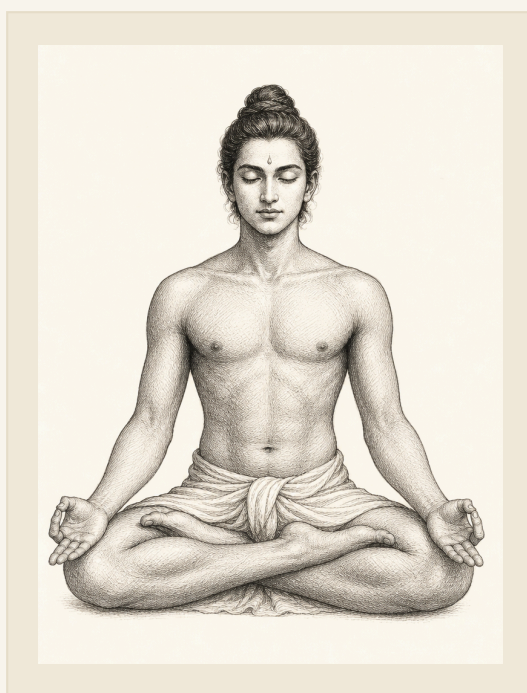
Continue only as long as it remains natural. When the eyes tire or begin to water heavily, move to Stage Two.

In time you will notice the flame itself seems to still, its usual flicker settling into something closer to a held, steady light. This is not the candle changing. It is your own attention settling into the same steadiness it is asked to hold.

Stage Two: The Closed Eye and the Held Afterimage

Close the eyes. An afterimage of the flame will appear, usually a small point or disc of light. Bring this afterimage to rest at the ajna, the point between and slightly above the eyebrows, and hold your inner gaze there.

This is Shambhavi Mudra, the classical gesture of turning the eyes toward the eyebrow centre. With the physical eyes closed, the inner eyes turn upward and inward to the same point, and the afterimage is held steady there rather than allowed to drift.



Eyes closed, attention gathered at the centre between the brows. The outer mark some traditions wear at this point is a reminder of exactly where the inner gaze belongs.

The afterimage will move, change colour, shrink, or fade entirely, only to sometimes return. This is normal and expected. Do not chase it if it moves; simply return attention to the ajna and let the image reappear or not, as it will. Most practitioners find the afterimage returns two or three times, fading a little further with each return, before it is finally, completely gone.

WHEN THE AFTERIMAGE IS GONE

Once the afterimage has completely disappeared and does not return, the closed-eye stage is complete. At this point, rather than straining to hold an image that is no longer there, allow a few soft blinks with the eyes still closed if needed to settle them, then open the eyes and return to Stage One, gazing again at the physical flame. Repeat the two stages for as many rounds as the session allows.

This alternation, open gaze, closed gaze and held afterimage, open gaze again, is the complete engine of the practice. Nothing else is required. What follows in the next section is an addition many practitioners are ready for once the basic rhythm is comfortable, not a replacement for it.

Holding the Chakras While Gazing

Once the two-stage rhythm of gazing is familiar, a second thread of attention can be added alongside it. This does not replace the gaze; it runs underneath it, a quieter awareness held at one point along the spine while the eyes continue their own work at the wick and at the ajna.

We hold this second attention at five points, moving from the base of the spine upward: the base of the spine itself, the point opposite the pubic bone, a point on the back at the level of the heart, a point on the back at the level of the throat, and finally the bindu, at the very back of the crown of the head.

POINT	LOCATION	COMMON NAME
First	Base of the spine	Muladhara
Second	Opposite the pubic bone, on the front of the body	Svadhithana
Third	Back of the body, level with the heart	Anahata (rear point)
Fourth	Back of the body, level with the throat	Vishuddha (rear point)
Fifth	Bindu, at the back of the crown	Bindu

Notice that three of these five points are held on the back of the body rather than the front. This is deliberate. Holding attention at the rear of the heart and throat, rather than their more familiar front-facing positions, draws energy along the spine itself rather than out into the more commonly worked frontal centres.

Sequencing the Second Attention

There are two ways to work with these five points, and both are used within our school. Choose whichever suits the season of practice you are in, and feel free to move between them.

Two ways of sequencing

- **Within a single session:** Move through all five points in one sitting, spending a portion of the session at each, base to bindu, before returning to ordinary gazing to close the practice.
- **Across a week:** Hold a single point for an entire week of daily practice, then move to the next point the following week. After the fifth week, at the bindu, begin again at the base of the spine.

In either approach, the second attention is held lightly. The primary task remains the gaze itself, at the wick and then at the ajna. The point along the spine is a background awareness, felt rather than stared at, the way you might remain aware of your own hands resting in your lap without looking at them.

Over time, this second attention tends to draw a subtle current with it, a felt sense of movement or warmth tracing the spine between whichever point is being held and the ajna where the gaze itself rests. Let this happen without forcing it. It arises on its own from the combination of the steady gaze and the quieter, background attention beneath it.

PARTFOUR. THE AKASHIC TRANCE

VIII

Feeling the Space Around You

As the practice deepens, a further quality often appears on its own: an awareness not just of the gaze and the second attention at the spine, but of the space surrounding the body itself. This is worth naming directly, because many practitioners feel it before they have any language for it, and mistake it for a distraction rather than the practice doing exactly what it is meant to do.

We want this. Feel the space around you, the room, the air, the quiet volume that contains the body sitting in front of the candle. Let this felt sense of space be included in the practice rather than pushed aside in favour of a narrower focus.

RECOGNISING THE TRANCE

As the eyes still, the mind still, and the second attention settles along the spine, a trance state tends to arise on its own. It may feel like a thickening of the space around you, a sense of depth or weight in the silence, or simply a marked slowing of thought. Recognise it when it comes. Do not analyse it or try to hold onto it by force. Simply notice it is here, and allow yourself to deepen into it, the way you might sink further into a warm bath once you notice you are already in it.

PARTFOUR. THE AKASHIC TRANCE

IX

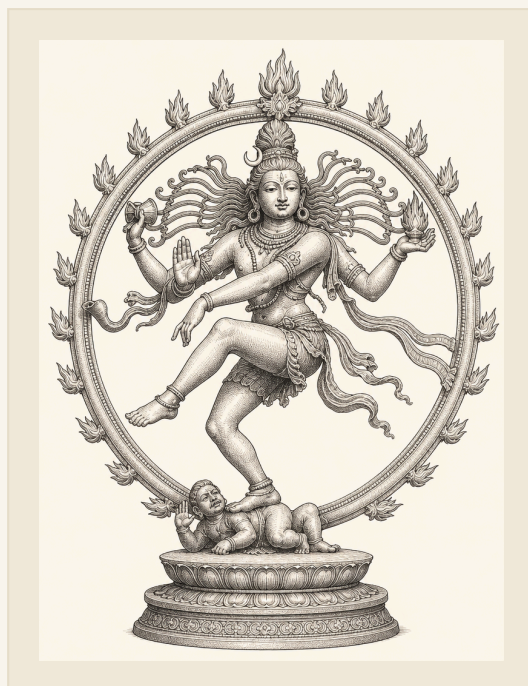
The Descent Into Akasha

The full sequence this practice moves through can be stated as a single descending formula, one condition giving rise to the next.

When the eyes are still, the mind is still. When the mind is still, the breath slows or stops. When the breath slows, we enter the akasha. When the akasha is rested in, samadhi awakens.

Akasha is usually translated as space or ether, but within this practice it is better understood directly rather than through translation. It is the felt quality of open space that appears once the ordinary business of the eyes, the mind, and the breath has quieted enough to stop obscuring it. It was always here. The practice does not create it. It simply stops covering it over.

We will return to akasha again in future study, particularly through the lens of the hermetic tradition, where the same principle appears under different names. For now, it is enough to recognise it directly in your own practice: the particular quality of stillness that arises once breath has slowed and the mind has stopped its usual movement.



Shiva Nataraja, Lord of the Dance, poised within a circle of flame: stillness and motion held as a single form, an image long associated with the space, akasha, that contains all movement.

Samadhi is not forced open by will. It is what remains once every layer standing in front of it, the moving eye, the moving mind, the moving breath, has been allowed to settle on its own. This is why the practice asks so little of you beyond patience: gaze, allow the afterimage its returns, hold the second attention lightly, and let the rest happen in its own time.

PART FIVE. DRISHTI AND THE WIDER FIELD

X

Drishti Points in the Wider Tradition

Candle gazing is one form among a much wider family of gazing practices found across yoga and tantra, generally referred to as drishti, gaze or gazing point. Different traditions and different postures call for the gaze to rest in different places, and it is worth knowing a few of the more common ones, even where they are not our central practice.

Common gaze points

- **Bhrumadhya drishti:** The eyebrow centre, the same point used for the afterimage in Shambhavi Mudra.
- **Nasagra drishti:** The tip of the nose, commonly used in seated postures and certain pranayama practices.
- **Nabi drishti:** The navel, used in some hatha postures to draw attention to the centre of the body.
- **Angustha drishti:** The thumb or a raised hand, used in various asana.

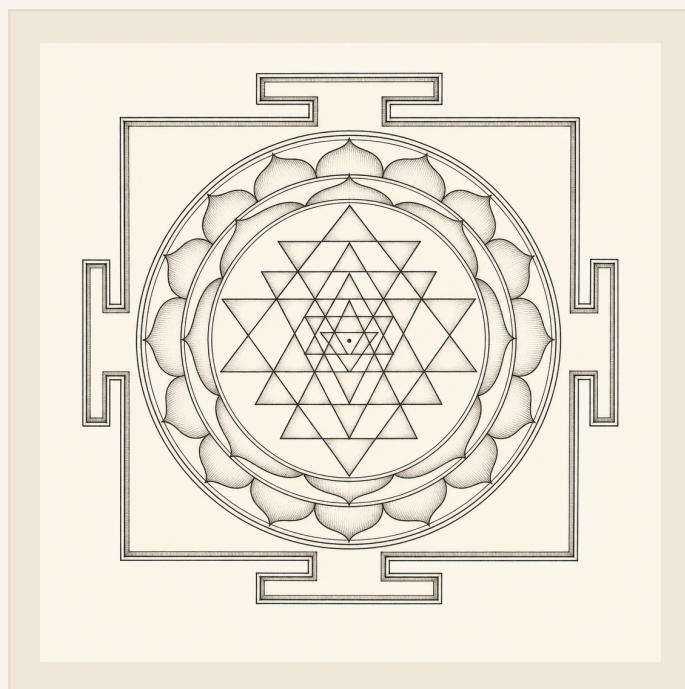
What all of these share with Jyoti Trataka is the underlying principle already stated: a fixed point for the eyes quiets the wandering of the mind. Candle gazing is simply the most complete and self-contained expression of that principle available to a solitary practitioner, requiring no teacher present and no elaborate setting beyond a flame and a dark room.

PART FIVE. DRISHTI AND THE WIDER FIELD

XI

A First Word on Yantra

Alongside the candle, the wall point, and the tip of the nose, tantric practice also gazes upon the yantra, a geometric diagram understood as a structured field for the eye and the mind to rest within and move through.



The Sri Yantra, most celebrated of the tantric yantras: nine interlocking triangles surrounding a central point, the bindu, understood as the seed from which the entire diagram, and the entire manifest universe it represents, unfolds.

A yantra is gazed upon much as the candle is gazed upon, attention resting on the central bindu while the surrounding geometry holds the peripheral field steady. The same descending sequence applies: stillness of eye, stillness of mind, slowing of breath, entry into akasha.

This document is not the place for a full account of yantra practice; that deserves, and will receive, its own dedicated study at a later point. For now, it is enough to see that gazing meditation is not a single technique but a broad and ancient family, of which the candle before you is one complete, sufficient, and endlessly deepening member.

One flame. One point between the brows. One breath, slowing. One space, always already here.

FURTHER READING
BIBLIOGRAPHY

Further Reading and Resources

This teaching draws on the classical hatha and tantric sources that describe Trataka and its wider family of gazing practices. The following are warmly recommended for those who wish to go deeper.

Classical Sources

- **Hatha Yoga Pradipika**, Svamimarama. The classical manual that names Trataka among the six purificatory acts (shatkarmas), praised for destroying disorders of the eye and inducing a form of divya drishti, divine sight.
- **Gheranda Samhita**, attributed to Gheranda. A detailed compendium of hatha practice, describing Trataka as gazing without blinking until the eyes fill with tears, a discipline said to remove sloth and steady the mind.
- **Shiva Samhita**, trans. various. A tantric hatha text situating gazing and concentration practices within a broader map of the subtle body and its centres.

Tantric and Related Sources

- **Vijnana Bhairava Tantra**, trans. various. A tantric text of one hundred and twelve dharanas, several of which use fixed gazing, the space between the eyes, and the felt sense of surrounding space as direct gateways into awareness.
- **Sri Yantra and the Shri Vidya tradition**, various. The living tradition of yantra as an object of gazing meditation, of which this document offers only a first word.